

of making each citizen's interaction with KDMC easy, simple, and efficient, while ensuring accountability and transparency.

The Coimbatore Municipal Corporation (CMC) has used e-governance for a "Anytime, Anywhere" governance. This has helped CMC in making their administrative processes transparent, efficient and productive. It also helped in creating a simple, friendly and efficient interface for their citizens.

Another issue that has almost become synonymous with e-governance in India is the financing of the e-governance projects, or more precisely the financing mechanism of Public Private Partnership (PPP).

It is an old mechanism of engaging with private partners, namely private companies as well as non-governmental organisations (NGOs) to bridge the gap in the quality, speed and efficiency in the service delivery process in the public sector. In e-governance, this partnership has been cemented in public projects like creation of infrastructure and pro-

agement, still the basic tools of change management are being ignored in the rush to come out with projects on the ground.

Change management should start even before the project itself has been identified. If the project affects the departments then one should have mechanisms to involve the departments for conceptualising the project and then keeping them informed about the progress of the project as well as key decisions involving the project.

A mechanism that has been widely adopted is to have extended workshops to educate the departments on the management issues of e-governance and the possibilities opened up by e-governance. Having done that, the departments would be in a position to articulate their requirements, based on which projects can be conceptualised. Such a process also helps in reducing the "re-inventing of the wheel" by reducing re-development of common applications.

It also helps in prioritising the applications to

“ Once the government has its backend in place and has crystallised its application and IT architectures, it would be in a position to roll out citizen-oriented services. ”

visioning of services in the entire gamut of activities relating to hardware, application software, maintenance, finance and other activities.

Governments have limited resources, and hence cannot achieve everything by themselves. There is already a financial crunch for investing in and improving basic facilities like education, health care and infrastructure projects in roads, power plants etc. Few governments have ready-cash for investing in IT-infrastructure projects.

Therefore, governments are taking advantage of the complementary strengths of private players to achieve the best results in the shortest possible time.

In fact, e-Governance projects are infrastructure projects requiring large investments into an area that is not the Government's core competence. Moreover, there are multiple risks involved in such projects. These risks are mainly technology risks, financial risks, operational risks and user acceptability risks. Therefore the governments need to leverage its limited resources, which is where private financing and operating skills come in handy.

Finally, comes the issue of change management. Although most governments who have seriously started off on the path to e-governance are aware of the perils of ignoring change man-

be developed by identifying the common applications that needs to be rolled out. The workshop approach also helps in creating an appropriate technology architecture that can be centralized as apriori the government can get a view of the total requirement of all the departments.

Finally, the workshop helps in getting the buy-in and ownership for the solutions so that during the actual implementation of the solution, the departments extend their full support to the project. This is absolutely critical as such large and complex projects are highly people dependent.

India is being looked upon as a source of innovative low cost e-governance solutions that are appropriate for countries besotted with poor physical infrastructure around the world. So not only should we be developing and implementing the best-in-class solutions for e-governance for the sake of a more efficient government and consequently a more efficient domestic economy but also because it is our responsibility to be the thought leaders in e-governance in order to help out countries facing similar socio-economic issues. And of course, no one is in doubt that the Indian central, state and local governments will stand up to this challenge, but the issue is how efficiently and how fast can they show the results. ■